



Parents and Carers · Primary · Session 4

# Home and Community

# Distress and unmet needs

What we see is often only the tip of the iceberg.

## Behaviour

What we can see and hear.

## Underneath

Thoughts and feelings, values, and needs such as belonging, predictability, security and self-expression.

A reaction is rarely a choice. It usually makes sense once we understand what came before: an unexpected change, too much noise, a demand that was too big on that day.

**Behaviour is communication. Be curious about what sits underneath.**

# Overwhelm

## Shutdown

Turning inward. Freeze or flop. Less able to speak or say what they need. Can be hidden or masked.

## Meltdown

Turning outward. Fight or flight. Might look like crying, running away or a big emotional outburst.

**These are involuntary responses to overwhelm, not a choice.**

# When overwhelm builds up

## Autistic burnout

Deep physical, mental and emotional exhaustion after a long time of too much sensory and social demand. Skills and capacity can drop for a while.

## School Can't

Not being able to go to school because of overwhelming anxiety, fear or sensory overload. It is not a choice or defiance.

Burnout and School Can't are often signs that a child has been coping with more than we realised, for longer than we realised. Looking underneath helps us find the support, adjustments and recovery they need.

# What can help in the moment?

**Be curious, not judgemental.**

**Reduce input: fewer words, fewer questions, less noise.**

**Have a safe, quiet space you have agreed on before.**

**Remember it is a body response. They are doing the best they can.**

**Talking it through can wait until they are calm.**

# Self-regulation and co-regulation

## Co-regulation

A calm, trusted adult helps your child settle. Your steady presence does a lot of the work.

## Self-regulation

What your child does to manage their own energy and feelings. It grows over time, with support.

**Co-regulation comes first. Self-regulation builds from it.**

# The after-school crash

Many Autistic children hold it together at school and let go at home.

## Recovery first

Food, quiet, movement or screen time, their choice, before any questions or demands.

## Talk later

"How was school?" can wait. They may tell you later, often late in the evening, or not at all.

## Homework can wait too

Straight after school, the battery is often empty.

## Keep it the same

A simple after-school routine they can rely on.

# Predictability at home

**Predictability lowers everyone's load, and home does not need to feel like school.**

## **A few routines**

Pick the ones that help your family most: mornings, after school, bedtime.

## **Visual supports**

A schedule on the fridge or a now-and-next card, where they help.

## **Warnings**

Warn before a change or transition, and mean it: "five more minutes".

## **When plans change**

Name it, show it, and give as much warning as you can.

# Interests are an anchor

## Regulation

Time with an interest can restore energy faster than almost anything else.

## Connection

Their interest is a way in. Connection often starts inside their world.

## Joy and identity

Deep interests are part of who they are, not something to ration.

Taking an interest away as a consequence often makes regulation harder.

# Planning an outing

**A party, the shops, a swimming lesson. What do you already do to plan for it?**

- 1 Before: preview it. What, where, how long, and what happens if it is too much?
- 2 During: watch their energy, not the clock. A planned exit is a good plan, not a failure.
- 3 After: plan recovery time.
- 4 Share one idea with your table. Add ideas from others to your workbook.

# Siblings and family life

## Their own time

Siblings see a lot and carry some. Small, regular one-on-one time helps.

## Fair is not the same

Each child gets what they need. It can help to say that out loud.

## Words that fit their age

Siblings understand more when they have language for what is going on.

**It's okay that it's hard. Balance is something you keep working on.**

# Your own battery counts

## It helps your child

It is hard to help someone else stay calm when you are running on empty.

## Small and daily

Ten minutes, a walk, a cup of tea in peace, asking for help.

## Your supports

A partner, family, friends, other parents. The people in this room are one of them.

Looking after yourself is part of looking after your family.

# Let's share what works

**Families know a lot. Share one thing that works in your home.**

- 1 Mornings, after school, outings, bedtime, siblings or your own battery.
- 2 Each person shares one idea with the table.
- 3 Write down one idea you would like to try.